

25 things you didn't know about Windows Vista

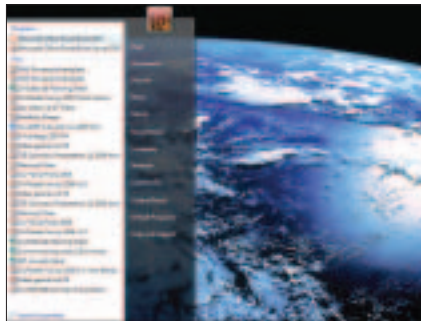
Windows Vista offers a huge range of new tools, features and functions, many of which you may not have even heard about. Here's our run down of Vista's best kept secrets

When Vista was launched last year, Microsoft chose a surprisingly narrow selection of new features to shout about during the promotion of the latest Windows version. In fact, there's a lot more to Vista than you might think, and perhaps the most impressive aspect of all is the sheer number of tools that have been introduced or updated to improve the home computing experience. From protection to productivity, and communication to customisation, there are dozens of handy new features — some of which are less well advertised than others.

We provide you in-depth advice and step-by-step guides that demonstrate how to find and use many of the great lesser-known features, tools and settings included in Windows Vista. But before we get down to the fine detail, let's take a moment to introduce some of things you may or may not already know your PC can do.

1. Find anything, fast

Vista has completely changed the way you search for documents, programs and settings. Unlike XP's Start menu, you don't have to manually hunt down what you need. Just press the [Windows] key and start typing the name of what you're looking for. As you type, Vista scours your hard disk for all files, programs and even its own settings for items that match, displaying applications at the top of



Can't find a file or a program? Vista's new Instant Search tool will track it down in a flash

the list and documents in the lower portion. The more characters you type, the more Vista filters out the results. Use it to find the features we're talking about throughout this introduction.

2. Flip through windows

When Vista first appeared, much was made of its new look. But the appearance isn't just skin deep — the new interface provides a handy way to browse the applications and documents open on your PC. It's called Flip 3D and to use it just to hold down the Windows key and press Tab. Vista then displays a 3D image of all the programs you have open; pressing the Tab key again flips to the next application. This feature is not available in Vista Home Basic.

3. Print without waste

Most of us have felt at some point the need to print out a web page. In XP, printing web pages could be a frustrating experience, with ink and paper wasted as elements of the page that fell outside of a conventional A4 sheet were printed on new pages. Internet Explorer 7, which is included with Vista, has a Print Preview tool that enables you to manage how pages print. To access it, click the down arrow next to the printer icon at the top-right of the window.



Zero waste: Only print the bits you need with IE7

4. Keep the kids in check

Enquiring minds are to be encouraged, but meddling fingers can play havoc with your settings. Children need to be protected and supervised when using your PC, and Vista can help you do this. Vista Parental Controls enable you to set specific times of the week when children can use the computer and block access to inappropriate websites and specific programs. Type 'parental' into the Start menu search box (see tip 1) to access the controls.

5. Record TV

With Windows Media Center, you can watch and record programs, providing you have a TV tuner built in or attached to the comput-